FUTURE CAREER SCHOOL

Career Chart After 10th: All Routes

Every route open after Class 10 in India, on a few pages you can print and keep

Last checked October 2026
futurecareerschool.com

Start at the top question. Follow the arrows to a first lean, then test that route with the checks on the last pages. Your route sets which doors open; the skill you build on top decides how high your income can go.

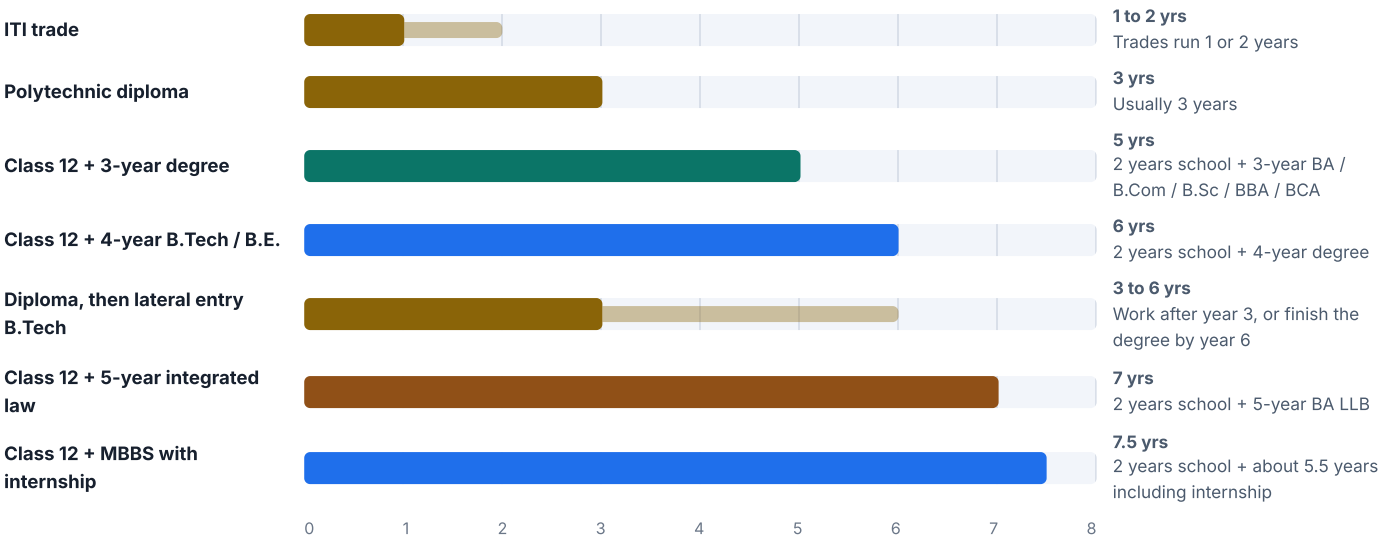
Step 1 · Follow the decision flow

- **Does your family need you earning within about 1 to 3 years?**
  - Yes, soon →
    - **Which kind of work do you enjoy more?**
      - Using tools and fixing things by hand → **ITI trade course** 1–2 yrs to work
      - Drawings, circuits, machines and systems → **Polytechnic diploma** 3 yrs to work
      - Still not sure → **Skill-first stack beside school** 1–3 yrs to work
  - Not that soon →
    - **Which subject do you go back to when nobody is checking?**
      - Maths and Physics → **Science with Maths (PCM)** 5–6 yrs to work
      - Biology and living things → **Science with Biology (PCB)** 5–7.5 yrs to work
      - Money, markets and business →
        - **Can you work through Maths for two more years?**
          - Yes → **Commerce with Maths** 5 yrs to work
          - No, I would struggle → **Commerce without Maths** 5 yrs to work
      - People, language, society or design → **Arts and Humanities** 5–7 yrs to work
      - I like both Maths and Biology → **Science with both (PCMB)** 5–7.5 yrs to work
  - I cannot attend regular school → **Open schooling (NIOS and state open schools)** 2–3 yrs to work

This flow gives a first lean, not a verdict. Test the route it points to with the checks below before you commit.

Colour key: Science (Class 11–12, then a degree) Commerce (Class 11–12, then a degree or professional course) Arts and Humanities (Class 11–12, then a degree) Diploma and ITI (Technical route that starts at once) Flexible and add-on routes (Open schooling and skill-first stack)
Years to work counts from the day Class 10 ends to the earliest standard full-time start. It shows time, not pay.

Step 2 · How long until first full-time work



Years counted from the day Class 10 ends to the earliest standard full-time start. They show time, not pay. Postgraduate study, repeat attempts and licensing exams add years in some routes.

Step 3 · The chart: every route at a glance

ROUTE	WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN	WHAT IT CLOSES	YEARS TO WORK	SCALABILITY
Science with Maths (PCM) Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree	B.Tech / B.E. (4 years) through JEE Main, state engineering entrance tests, BITSAT and similar; B.Sc in Physics, Chemistry, Maths, Statistics, Computer Science and data subjects; BCA and other computing degrees	MBBS, BDS and other NEET-based medical courses (these need Biology)	**5–6 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** The doors it opens (engineering, computing, data) can grow into products and consulting, but the engineering entrance ladder is crowded and a branch degree alone is not scalable. *To grow: Add coding, automation or AI skills and build one project people use.*
Science with Biology (PCB) Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree	MBBS, BDS and other medical seats through NEET UG; B.Sc Nursing, physiotherapy, medical lab and other allied health courses (entry route differs by state; verify); B.Pharm and pharmacy routes (verify whether your state accepts PCB or needs Maths)	B.Tech / B.E. (these need Maths in Class 12)	**5–7.5 yrs**	**Not so scalable.** Its best-known doors (MBBS, BDS) mean competition at several levels and very few seats, so effort alone may not lead to a seat. The scalable doors are biotech, health-tech, nutrition and data. *To grow: Write a second route, and add a data, health-tech or science-communication skill beside Biology.*
Science with both (PCMB) Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree	Keeps both the engineering and the medical doors open until Class 12 ends	Nothing by itself	**5–7.5 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** It keeps the widest set of doors, but only the computing, data and biotech doors scale. Two heavy exam tracks at once can leave little time to build skills. *To grow: Choose one primary track early and keep one skill project running.*
Commerce with Maths Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree or professional course	B.Com, BBA, BMS, economics and statistics degrees; CA, CMA and CS professional ladders (ICAI has allowed provisional CA Foundation registration after Class 10, and the exam needs Class 12 appearance; confirm the current rule); Finance, analytics and actuarial-style routes that need Maths	B.Tech / B.E. and NEET medical routes	**5 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** Opens BCA, data, finance and business routes that scale, but CA and general management degrees are crowded unless you add a niche. *To grow: Learn spreadsheets, data and sales, and try a small real venture.*

ROUTE	WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN	WHAT IT CLOSES	YEARS TO WORK	SCALABILITY
Commerce without Maths Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree or professional course	B.Com, BBA, BMS and most business and accounting degrees; CA, CMA and CS routes; Integrated law and CUET-based BA and B.Com courses	Quantitative economics honours and some analytics or actuarial programmes that ask for Class 12 Maths; B.Tech / B.E. and NEET medical routes	**5 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** Business, finance and communication routes scale when you add a domain skill; a general degree alone is crowded. *To grow: Pair the degree with one applied skill: sales, accounting software, marketing or modelling.*
Arts and Humanities Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree	Law (5-year integrated BA LLB through CLAT or CUET-based seats); Psychology, sociology, economics, political science, journalism and mass communication degrees; Design and creative degrees through design entrance tests (NID, NIFT, UCEED and others)	B.Tech / B.E. and NEET medical routes	**5–7 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** Design, media, psychology and communication scale when you own an audience, a portfolio or a practice. Law and civil services are crowded ladders with few winners. *To grow: Build a portfolio or writing proof early and choose a niche.*
Polytechnic diploma Usually 3 years	Junior engineer, technician, supervisor and site roles after the diploma; Lateral entry into the second year of B.E. / B.Tech after a diploma (verify the state rules and the college); Apprenticeship training through NATS	NEET medical routes. The Class 12 science subjects are not studied, so check how a diploma is treated for the degree you want.	**3 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** A diploma alone has a fixed pay ladder. It scales when you add digital, automation or supervision skills, or run your own technical service. *To grow: Use lateral entry or a skill project to move up, and learn automation.*
ITI trade course 1 or 2 years, depending on the trade	Skilled trade jobs and supervised work in industry; Apprenticeship training through the Apprenticeship portals; Some states and institutes allow ITI holders to join a diploma in the second year (verify)	A direct route to degree seats unless you add Class 12 (open schooling) or a diploma bridge	**1–2 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** Trade pay starts low. It scales when you run your own service business (repair, installation, solar, electrical work) and add digital or safety skills. *To grow: Take an apprenticeship, then offer your trade as a service.*
Open schooling (NIOS and state open schools) Flexible. Admission stays valid for 5 years with public exams twice a year (April–May and October–November), per the NIOS prospectus	Completing Class 12 while working, training for a trade, or preparing for sport or arts; A route back to degree courses for students who left school, started an ITI, or did a diploma first; Subject combinations not offered in a nearby school	Nothing by itself. NIOS states its certificate is equivalent to other boards and accepted by universities, but some institutions set their own rules, so confirm for your course and subject group.	**2–3 yrs**	**Scalable with a business layer.** It gives time to build skills, and scales only if you use that time for real proof of work. *To grow: Use the time to build one skill and one finished project.*
Skill-first stack beside school Runs beside school, diploma or ITI	Proof of work (projects, drafts, small client tasks) that a mark sheet cannot show; Entry into skill-based roles after the route you choose; Earlier income options through freelance or part-time tasks, within your family's and the law's limits on work at your age	Nothing by itself	**1–3 yrs**	**Scalable.** You control the pace. A digital or craft skill with proof of work can be sold directly and can grow into consulting or a business. *To grow: Pick one skill, build three pieces of proof, then take paid projects.*

How we rate scalability: We rate a route Scalable when steady learning and a whole-picture approach (skills, proof of work, communication and a little business sense) can grow your income and reach into consulting or a business of your own. A route marked Scalable with a business layer is also a good option for us, as long as you plan that layer: consulting, a studio, a practice or a product. Crowded fields, long ladders of entrance exams and ranks, and careers where very few people reach the top after many years do not count as scalable, so we mark them Not so scalable and list the risk beside them. Well-known routes such as MBBS and BDS, NDA, government exams, integrated law, pilot training, merchant navy and pure research stay in the chart so you can see what they carry, but they are rated Not so scalable. Success there depends on beating rivals at stage after stage, many years pass before pay grows, and few people reach the top. Consistent effort alone does not guarantee a result. If you choose one, write a second route and keep a skill running that can grow on its own.

Step 4 · Route cards: entry, fit, watch-outs and a first move

SCIENCE

Science with Maths (PCM) · Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree · about 5–6 yrs to first full-time work

Physics, Chemistry, Maths

ENTRY

Class 10 pass. Many schools set their own minimum in Maths and Science for this group, so ask the school before you count on a seat.

BEST FOR

Students who enjoy solving problems step by step, can sit with Maths and Physics for two years, and want engineering, computing or research left open.

WATCH OUT

Taking PCM because everyone else did. A weak Maths base shows up in Class 11 within a term, and two drifting years are expensive.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. The doors it opens (engineering, computing, data) can grow into products and consulting, but the engineering entrance ladder is crowded and a branch degree alone is not scalable. To grow: Add coding, automation or AI skills and build one project people use.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- B.Tech / B.E. (4 years) through JEE Main, state engineering entrance tests, BITSAT and similar
- B.Sc in Physics, Chemistry, Maths, Statistics, Computer Science and data subjects
- BCA and other computing degrees
- Architecture (needs Maths, plus the architecture aptitude test)
- NDA: the Air Force and Navy wings need Physics and Maths in Class 12

WHAT IT CLOSES

- MBBS, BDS and other NEET-based medical courses (these need Biology)

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Solve a full chapter of Class 11 Maths and Physics on your own and note where you got stuck and where you wanted to keep going.

SCIENCE

Science with Biology (PCB) · Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree · about 5–7.5 yrs to first full-time work

Physics, Chemistry, Biology

ENTRY

Class 10 pass. Many schools set their own minimum in Science for this group.

BEST FOR

Students who are drawn to the human body, plants, animals or lab work, and who accept that medicine is a long road with few seats.

WATCH OUT

Treating NEET as the only reason to take Biology. MBBS seats are scarce, so write a second route (allied health, life sciences, pharmacy) before results, not after.

SCALABILITY

Not so scalable. Its best-known doors (MBBS, BDS) mean competition at several levels and very few seats, so effort alone may not lead to a seat. The scalable doors are biotech, health-tech, nutrition and data. To grow: Write a second route, and add a data, health-tech or science-communication skill beside Biology.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- MBBS, BDS and other medical seats through NEET UG
- B.Sc Nursing, physiotherapy, medical lab and other allied health courses (entry route differs by state; verify)
- B.Pharm and pharmacy routes (verify whether your state accepts PCB or needs Maths)
- B.Sc in life sciences, biotechnology, microbiology, agriculture and veterinary routes (check the entrance test)

WHAT IT CLOSES

- B.Tech / B.E. (these need Maths in Class 12)

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Spend one day with a nurse, lab technician, pharmacist or doctor you can reach through family or school, and list the tasks they actually did.

SCIENCE

Science with both (PCMB) · Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree · about 5–7.5 yrs to first full-time work

Physics, Chemistry, Maths, Biology

ENTRY

Class 10 pass. Not every school offers the combination, and the load is the heaviest of all.

BEST FOR

Students who are genuinely strong in both Maths and Biology and are still undecided between engineering and medicine.

WATCH OUT

Picking it to avoid a decision. Five heavy subjects often lower scores in all of them, which weakens both doors.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. It keeps the widest set of doors, but only the computing, data and biotech doors scale. Two heavy exam tracks at once can leave little time to build skills. To grow: Choose one primary track early and keep one skill project running.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- Keeps both the engineering and the medical doors open until Class 12 ends

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Check last year's school results for the PCMB group and ask how many students scored well in both Maths and Biology.

COMMERCE

Commerce with Maths · Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree or professional course · about 5 yrs to first full-time work

Accountancy, Business Studies, Economics, Maths

ENTRY

Class 10 pass. Maths in Class 10 helps; some schools ask for a minimum.

BEST FOR

Students who like money, markets, numbers, how businesses make profit, or who come from a family business and want to run it better.

WATCH OUT

Choosing commerce as an easy stream. Accountancy and Economics reward steady practice, and a degree without any applied skill leads to the lowest-paid desk jobs.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. Opens BCA, data, finance and business routes that scale, but CA and general management degrees are crowded unless you add a niche. To grow: Learn spreadsheets, data and sales, and try a small real venture.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- B.Com, BBA, BMS, economics and statistics degrees
- CA, CMA and CS professional ladders (ICAI has allowed provisional CA Foundation registration after Class 10, and the exam needs Class 12 appearance; confirm the current rule)
- Finance, analytics and actuarial-style routes that need Maths
- Integrated law (BBA LLB) and management routes through CUET or CLAT

WHAT IT CLOSES

- B.Tech / B.E. and NEET medical routes

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Read one company's annual report summary or a small shop's monthly accounts and write what makes its profit rise and fall.

COMMERCE

Commerce without Maths · Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree or professional course · about 5 yrs to first full-time work

Accountancy, Business Studies, Economics, plus an elective

ENTRY

Class 10 pass.

BEST FOR

Students who want business or accounting but are sure Maths will not carry them for two more years.

WATCH OUT

Dropping Maths without checking the programmes you may want later. Some doors can be reopened with bridge courses, but it costs time.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. Business, finance and communication routes scale when you add a domain skill; a general degree alone is crowded. To grow: Pair the degree with one applied skill: sales, accounting software, marketing or modelling.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- B.Com, BBA, BMS and most business and accounting degrees
- CA, CMA and CS routes
- Integrated law and CUET-based BA and B.Com courses

WHAT IT CLOSES

- Quantitative economics honours and some analytics or actuarial programmes that ask for Class 12 Maths
- B.Tech / B.E. and NEET medical routes

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

List three degrees you might want after Class 12 and check each one's Class 12 subject rule on its own admission page.

ARTS AND HUMANITIES

Arts and Humanities · Class 11 and 12 (2 years), then a degree · about 5–7 yrs to first full-time work

History, Political Science, Geography, Sociology, Psychology, Economics and more

ENTRY

Class 10 pass. Available in most schools; subject combinations vary by school.

BEST FOR

Students who read, write, argue, observe people, design or create, and who are ready to build proof of work instead of waiting for a job title.

WATCH OUT

Finishing the degree with no visible work. Arts degrees pay when they are paired with a portfolio, writing samples, a research brief or a communication skill.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. Design, media, psychology and communication scale when you own an audience, a portfolio or a practice. Law and civil services are crowded ladders with few winners. To grow: Build a portfolio or writing proof early and choose a niche.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- Law (5-year integrated BA LLB through CLAT or CUET-based seats)
- Psychology, sociology, economics, political science, journalism and mass communication degrees
- Design and creative degrees through design entrance tests (NID, NIFT, UCEED and others)
- Teaching (integrated B.Ed routes and the teaching degree path)
- Hotel management (NCHM JEE) and many CUET-based BA courses
- Civil services and many government exams, which accept a degree in any subject

WHAT IT CLOSES

- B.Tech / B.E. and NEET medical routes

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Make one finished piece this month: a two-page explainer, a short design, a recorded talk or a small research note on a topic you chose.

DIPLOMA AND ITI

Polytechnic diploma · Usually 3 years · about 3 yrs to first full-time work

Civil, Mechanical, Electrical, Electronics, Computer and other branches

ENTRY

Class 10 pass. Admission is usually through the state technical education board by merit or an entrance test, so rules and cut-offs differ by state.

BEST FOR

Students who learn best through labs, drawings, machines and systems, want to earn earlier, and are willing to check the institute before joining.

WATCH OUT

Joining the nearest institute without checking approval, labs, faculty and what its own students did after passing. The label is the same, the quality is not.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. A diploma alone has a fixed pay ladder. It scales when you add digital, automation or supervision skills, or run your own technical service. To grow: Use lateral entry or a skill project to move up, and learn automation.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- Junior engineer, technician, supervisor and site roles after the diploma
- Lateral entry into the second year of B.E. / B.Tech after a diploma (verify the state rules and the college)
- Apprenticeship training through NATS
- Self-employment in services such as electrical, networking and repair work

WHAT IT CLOSES

- NEET medical routes. The Class 12 science subjects are not studied, so check how a diploma is treated for the degree you want.

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Visit the institute's lab on a working day, ask for last year's placement or lateral-entry list, and confirm approval on the official regulator site.

DIPLOMA AND ITI

ITI trade course · 1 or 2 years, depending on the trade · about 1–2 yrs to first full-time work

Electrician, Fitter, Welder, Mechanic, COPA and 160+ other trades

ENTRY

Minimum education depends on the trade: some accept Class 8 pass, many need Class 10. Admission is usually through the state, so verify the trade's own rule.

BEST FOR

Students who learn faster by doing than by sitting through theory, want the shortest gap to a skilled job, and are ready to keep adding skills.

WATCH OUT

Stopping at the certificate. The trade is the base; communication, digital skill, safety knowledge and a record of finished work decide how far it grows.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. Trade pay starts low. It scales when you run your own service business (repair, installation, solar, electrical work) and add digital or safety skills. To grow: Take an apprenticeship, then offer your trade as a service.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- Skilled trade jobs and supervised work in industry
- Apprenticeship training through the Apprenticeship portals
- Some states and institutes allow ITI holders to join a diploma in the second year (verify)
- Self-employment as an electrician, technician, mechanic or plumber

WHAT IT CLOSES

- A direct route to degree seats unless you add Class 12 (open schooling) or a diploma bridge

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Visit a local workshop for the trade you like, watch a working day, and ask the owner what separates a well-paid worker from a poorly paid one.

FLEXIBLE AND ADD-ON ROUTES

Open schooling (NIOS and state open schools) · Flexible. Admission stays valid for 5 years with public exams twice a year (April–May and October–November), per the NIOS prospectus · about 2–3 yrs to first full-time work

Study Class 11–12 on a flexible schedule, often while working

ENTRY

Class 10 pass from a recognised board and a minimum age of 15 (NIOS prospectus rules; confirm the current prospectus). At least five subjects must be passed, with one or two languages.

BEST FOR

Students who must earn, travel for training or sport, have health reasons, or are returning to study after a break.

WATCH OUT

Treating it as a lesser route. It needs more self-discipline than a regular school, because nobody checks your daily progress.

SCALABILITY

Scalable with a business layer. It gives time to build skills, and scales only if you use that time for real proof of work. To grow: Use the time to build one skill and one finished project.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- Completing Class 12 while working, training for a trade, or preparing for sport or arts
- A route back to degree courses for students who left school, started an ITI, or did a diploma first
- Subject combinations not offered in a nearby school

WHAT IT CLOSES

- Nothing by itself. NIOS states its certificate is equivalent to other boards and accepted by universities, but some institutions set their own rules, so confirm for your course and subject group.

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Download the current prospectus from the official site and read the subject groups and the exam-session rules before you decide.

FLEXIBLE AND ADD-ON ROUTES

Skill-first stack beside school · Runs beside school, diploma or ITI · about 1–3 yrs to first full-time work

A job-linked skill built alongside any route

ENTRY

No entry gate. A phone or computer, internet access and finished work are enough to begin.

BEST FOR

Every student. This is the layer that raises the income ceiling of whichever route you pick.

WATCH OUT

Collecting certificates. A certificate without a finished piece of work is easy to copy and easy for a reviewer to ignore.

SCALABILITY

Scalable. You control the pace. A digital or craft skill with proof of work can be sold directly and can grow into consulting or a business. To grow: Pick one skill, build three pieces of proof, then take paid projects.

WHAT IT KEEPS OPEN

- Proof of work (projects, drafts, small client tasks) that a mark sheet cannot show
- Entry into skill-based roles after the route you choose
- Earlier income options through freelance or part-time tasks, within your family's and the law's limits on work at your age

FIRST MOVE THIS MONTH

Choose one skill that matches your route and finish one small, real piece of work with it, then show it to one person who does that work.

Five mistakes to avoid

- **Choosing by marks alone.** High marks tell you what you can enter, not what you can sustain for two to five years.
- **Copying friends or relatives.** The route that worked for a cousin worked for their strengths, money and city.
- **Dropping Maths or Biology without checking.** Maths is needed for B.Tech and Biology for NEET medical seats. Check what you may want before you drop either.
- **Paying before verifying.** Check that the institute is approved, the fee is the total fee and the course is recognised.
- **Treating the route as the whole plan.** Every route leads to crowded and well-paid rows alike. The skill layer on top is what separates them.

Test every route you shortlist: the 4 checkpoints

1 Biology
How do you actually work best: abstract study, business thinking, people, or tools and systems? Choose the daily reality, not the label.

2 Context
Marks, money, family situation, school options, commute and emotional readiness. A route right on paper can be wrong for now.

3 Market
Where does the route lead later: real roles, real skills, real progression? Map it forward before you choose.

4 Survival
Will it hold up in an AI-shaped market? Domain skill plus communication, digital fluency and judgment lasts longer than routine work.

Then pass the 3 gates before money or years are locked in

1 Proof of Skill
Complete one small real task that resembles the route before you lock it.

2 Proof of Communication
Explain in 30 to 90 seconds why the route fits you, where it leads and what you will test next.

3 Proof of Value
Get grounded feedback from a teacher, senior or professional who does this work, and pressure-test your reasoning.

Your one-page plan (write it, do not just read it)

Route I am leaning toward:

Second route I would accept:

Subjects or trade I need for it:

The exam or entry rule I verified, and where:

One small real task I will finish this month:

The person I will ask for feedback:

Verify on the official source before you pay

SOURCE	USE IT FOR	LINK
NIOS (open schooling)	Open-school Secondary and Senior Secondary, vocational courses, study centres. The site states that the Association of Indian Universities has issued equivalence for the NIOS Senior Secondary certificate.	www.nios.ac.in/
DGT Craftsmen Training Scheme (ITI)	How the ITI network works. The page lists 14,643 ITIs and 169 NSQF-compliant trades (checked October 2026).	dgt.gov.in/en/CTS
NATS (apprenticeship training)	Apprenticeship-style, learn-while-working training for diploma and technical graduates.	nats.education.gov.in/about-us.php
AICTE	Check that a diploma or engineering institute is approved before paying.	www.aicte-india.org/

SOURCE	USE IT FOR	LINK
NTA (JEE Main, NEET UG, CUET UG)	Exam eligibility, syllabus and dates for the entrance tests that start after Class 12.	nta.ac.in/

Read this first: Entry rules, minimum marks, fees and seat numbers differ by state, board and year. Treat this chart as a map for asking better questions, then confirm every rule on the official site before you pay or lock a subject.

The route is the base layer. The skill portfolio on top raises your ceiling.
Find your strongest direction with the free Class 10 and below career assessment: futurecareerschool.com/services/assessments/class-10-and-below/
Personal help for you and your family: futurecareerschool.com/services/career-counselling-and-career-guidance/ · WhatsApp message from the site.
Full guide with explanations: futurecareerschool.com/blog/stream-selection/career-chart-after-10th/